

A SIX-DAY RETREAT IN DAILY LIFE

Blessed

Six Days with the Beatitudes



DAY ONE The Poor in Spirit *Matthew 5:1-3*

DAY TWO Those Who Mourn, the Gentle *Matthew 5:4-5*

DAY THREE Hunger and Mercy *Matthew 5:6-7*

DAY FOUR The Pure in Heart *Matthew 5:8*

DAY FIVE Peacemakers *Matthew 5:9-10*

DAY SIX Rejoice and Be Glad *Matthew 5:11-12*

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IGNATIUS AT HOME

How to Pray These Days



The Beatitudes open the Sermon on the Mount, and they turn the world upside down. Jesus looks at the crowd that has followed him up the hillside, the poor, the grieving, the hungry, the ones who have been pushed aside, and he calls them blessed. Not someday, once their troubles are over, but now, as they are.

For the next six days, spend one time of prayer a day with one or two of the Beatitudes. About twenty to thirty minutes is enough. Imagine yourself on the mountain, close enough to see his face as he speaks, and let each painting help you find your place in the crowd.

EACH DAY

- 1. Become still.** Find a quiet place. Sit comfortably, breathe slowly, and become aware that God is already present, looking at you with love.
- 2. Ask for the grace.** Each day names a grace. Ask for it plainly, as something you really want. Desire is where prayer begins.
- 3. Read slowly.** Read the passage aloud if you can, and then read it again. Stay with any word or phrase that holds you; there is no need to finish.
- 4. Enter the scene.** Use the painting and your imagination. Who is around you on the hillside? What does Jesus look like as he says these words to you?
- 5. Speak as a friend.** End by talking with Jesus in your own words, as one friend speaks to another. Close with the Our Father.
- 6. Notice.** Afterwards, take a moment to notice what stirred: consolation or desolation, peace or resistance. Jot down a word if it helps.

On the sixth day you will hear the Beatitudes whole again. Notice which one has become yours.

THE DAYS

DAY ONE The Poor in Spirit · *Matthew 5:1-3*

DAY TWO Those Who Mourn, the Gentle · *Matthew 5:4-5*

DAY THREE Hunger and Mercy · *Matthew 5:6-7*

DAY FOUR The Pure in Heart · *Matthew 5:8*

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DAY ONE

The Poor in Spirit

Matthew 5:1-3



The Sermon on the Mount, Carl Bloch, 1877

THE GRACE

Ask for the grace to sit at Jesus' feet on the mountain, and to know my need of God as a gift rather than a failure.

FOCUS

Come empty-handed today: notice what you are clinging to, and let Jesus call your poverty blessed.

¹ Seeing the multitudes, he went up onto the mountain. When he had sat down, his disciples came to him.

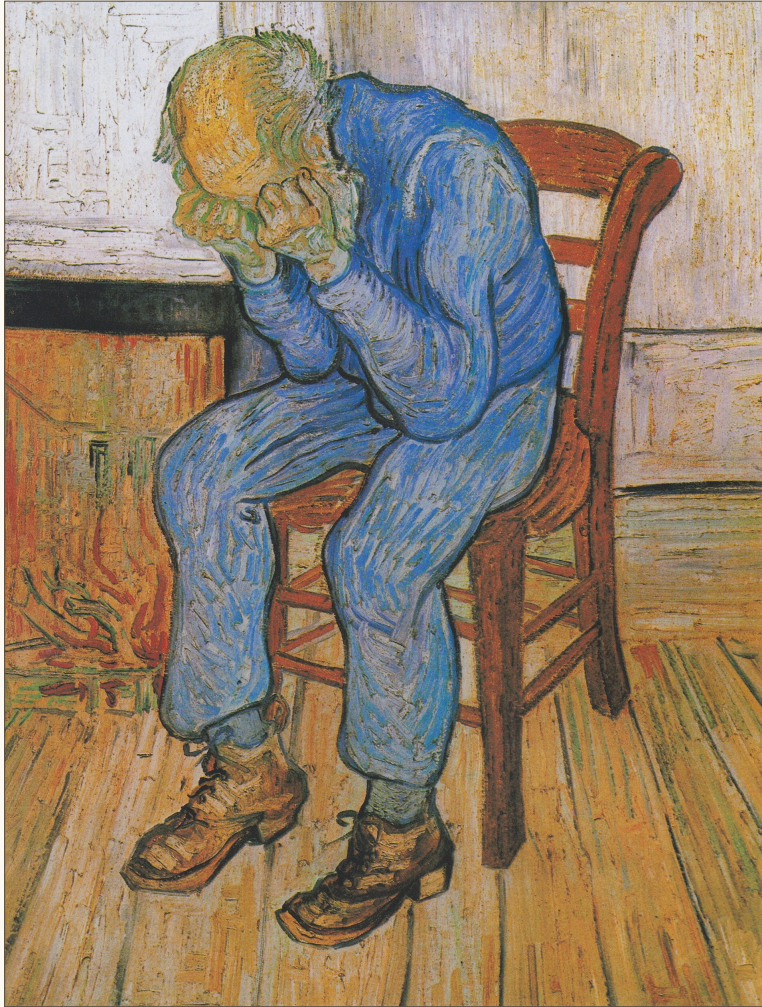
² He opened his mouth and taught them, saying,

³ “Blessed are the poor in spirit,
for theirs is the Kingdom of Heaven.

DAY TWO

Those Who Mourn, the Gentle

Matthew 5:4-5



Sorrowing Old Man ("At Eternity's Gate"), Vincent van Gogh, 1890

THE GRACE

Ask for the grace to bring my grief honestly to Jesus and to receive his comfort, and for a gentle heart that does not need to grasp.

FOCUS

Name one loss you are carrying, and let Jesus sit beside you in it without hurrying you.

⁴ Blessed are those who mourn,
for they shall be comforted.

⁵ Blessed are the gentle,
for they shall inherit the earth.

DAY THREE

Hunger and Mercy

Matthew 5:6-7



The Gleaners, Jean-François Millet, 1857

THE GRACE

Ask for the grace to hunger for what is right as deeply as I hunger for bread, and to show others the mercy I have been shown.

FOCUS

Notice who is gleaning at the edges of your field, and what mercy you might leave for them.

⁶ Blessed are those who hunger and thirst after righteousness,
for they shall be filled.

⁷ Blessed are the merciful,
for they shall obtain mercy.

DAY FOUR

The Pure in Heart

Matthew 5:8



The Annunciation, Fra Angelico, c. 1425–1426

THE GRACE

Ask for the grace of an undivided heart, open like Mary's, so that I may see God in all things.

FOCUS

Pray with Mary's "yes," and ask where God is quietly showing his face to you today.

8 Blessed are the pure in heart,
for they shall see God.

DAY FIVE

Peacemakers

Matthew 5:9-10



The Stoning of Saint Stephen, Rembrandt van Rijn, 1625

THE GRACE

Ask for the grace to make peace where there is division, and for the courage to stay faithful when doing right costs me something.

FOCUS

Like Stephen, who prayed for the people stoning him, pray today for someone who has wronged you.

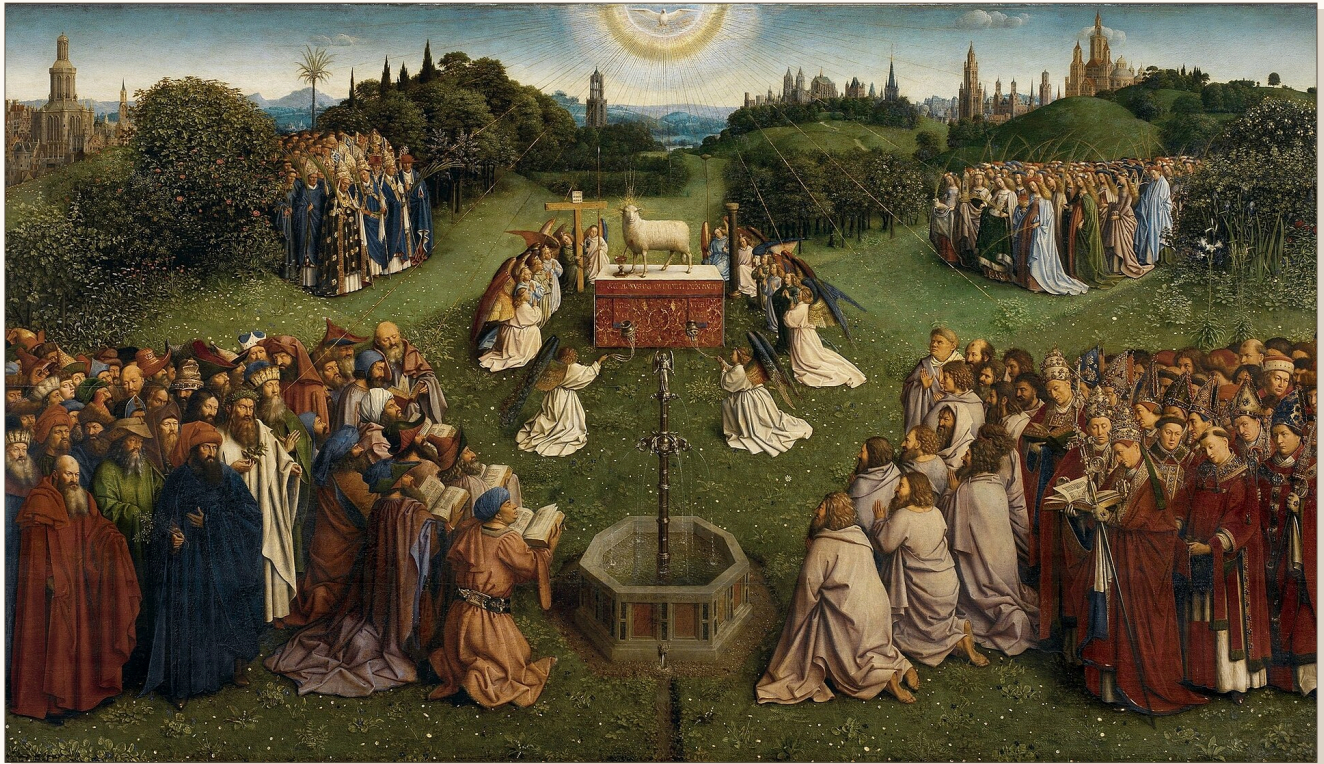
9 Blessed are the peacemakers,
for they shall be called children of God.

10 Blessed are those who have been persecuted for righteousness' sake,
for theirs is the Kingdom of Heaven.

DAY SIX

Rejoice and Be Glad

Matthew 5:11-12



The Adoration of the Mystic Lamb (Ghent Altarpiece, central panel), Jan van Eyck, 1432

THE GRACE

Ask for the grace to rejoice in belonging to Jesus, whatever it costs, and to see my life among the great company of the blessed.

FOCUS

Hear all the Beatitudes once more, slowly, and rest in the one that has become yours.

¹¹ “Blessed are you when people reproach you, persecute you, and say all kinds of evil against you falsely, for my sake. ¹² Rejoice, and be exceedingly glad, for great is your reward in heaven. For that is how they persecuted the prophets who were before you.

Return to the Whole

Matthew 5:1-12



Now read the Beatitudes from the beginning, slowly, as if you were hearing them for the first time. Pause after each one. Notice which one Jesus seems to be saying to you.

1 Seeing the multitudes, he went up onto the mountain. When he had sat down, his disciples came to him.

2 He opened his mouth and taught them, saying,

3 “Blessed are the poor in spirit,
for theirs is the Kingdom of Heaven.

4 Blessed are those who mourn,
for they shall be comforted.

5 Blessed are the gentle,
for they shall inherit the earth.

6 Blessed are those who hunger and thirst after righteousness,
for they shall be filled.

7 Blessed are the merciful,
for they shall obtain mercy.

8 Blessed are the pure in heart,
for they shall see God.

9 Blessed are the peacemakers,
for they shall be called children of God.

10 Blessed are those who have been persecuted for righteousness’ sake,
for theirs is the Kingdom of Heaven.

11 “Blessed are you when people reproach you, persecute you, and say all kinds of evil against you falsely, for my sake.

12 Rejoice, and be exceedingly glad, for great is your reward in heaven. For that is how they persecuted the prophets who were before you.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

Credits



SCRIPTURE

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PAINTINGS

DAY ONE

Carl Bloch (1834–1890), *The Sermon on the Mount*, 1877. Museum of National History, Frederiksborg Castle, Hillerød. Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

DAY TWO

Vincent van Gogh (1853–1890), *Sorrowing Old Man (“At Eternity’s Gate”)*, 1890. Kröller-Müller Museum, Otterlo. Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

DAY THREE

Jean-François Millet (1814–1875), *The Gleaners*, 1857. Musée d’Orsay, Paris. Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

DAY FOUR

Fra Angelico (c. 1395–1455), *The Annunciation*, c. 1425–1426. Museo del Prado, Madrid. Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

DAY FIVE

Rembrandt van Rijn (1606–1669), *The Stoning of Saint Stephen*, 1625. Musée des Beaux-Arts de Lyon. Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

DAY SIX

Jan van Eyck (c. 1390–1441) and Hubert van Eyck (d. 1426), *The Adoration of the Mystic Lamb (Ghent Altarpiece, central panel)*, 1432. Saint Bavo’s Cathedral, Ghent. Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

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